STUDENT WORKBOOK · HEALTH & PHYSICAL EDUCATION · TERM ___

SWIM & WATER SAFETY

Year 7–8 · Victorian Secondary School · Victorian Curriculum F–10 Version 2.0

STUDENT NAME	CLASS / GROUP	TEACHER
_____	_____	_____

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Curriculum: Victorian Curriculum F–10 Version 2.0

VC2HP8P08 · VC2HP8P09 · VC2HP8P10 · VC2HP8M01

Focus Areas: Safety (S) · Lifelong Physical Activities (LPA) · FMS

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Welcome to your Swim & Water Safety Workbook. Victoria has some of the most beautiful beaches, rivers, lakes and pools in Australia — and some of the most dangerous conditions. This workbook will help you build the knowledge, skills and confidence to keep yourself and others safe in and around water. Complete all activities thoughtfully and honestly.

1 Why Water Safety Matters in Victoria

KEY KNOWLEDGE — VICTORIAN DROWNING STATISTICS 2023–24

- 52 fatal drownings in Victoria in 2024–25 — 9% above the ten-year average
- Males are 4× more likely to drown than females
- Inland waterways (rivers, dams) are especially dangerous
- Non-fatal drownings were 60% above the 10-year average
- About 1 in 8 victims were aged 15–24 years old
- Zero deaths in public swimming pools — but 25% were in home environments
- Cold water shock can affect even strong swimmers
- 37% of deaths since 2015–16 were people from multicultural backgrounds (LSV)

Source: Life Saving Victoria Drowning Report 2023–24 — https://lsv.com.au/what-we-do/research-advocacy

Activity 1.1 — Personal Connection

Individual · ~5 min

Think about your own experiences near or in water. Answer the following questions honestly.

FAVOURITE WATER ENVIRONMENT (CIRCLE ONE):

Patrolled Beach · Unpatrolled Beach · Public Pool

Private Pool · River / Dam / Lake · I avoid water

MY SWIMMING ABILITY (CIRCLE ONE):

Non-swimmer / still learning

Can swim short distances

Comfortable swimmer

Strong / confident swimmer

Activity 1.2 — Data Analysis

Individual · ~10 min

Study the Victorian drowning statistics below. Complete the third column with your own interpretation of what each figure tells us.

Category	2023–24 Data	What does this tell us?
Total fatal drownings	**52 deaths**	*Write your interpretation here...*
Young people aged 15–24	**About 1 in 8 victims**	
Gender	**38 of 52 were male**	

Category	2023–24 Data	What does this tell us?
Location	**ALL at unpatrolled sites**	

QUESTION 1.2A — 2 MARKS

Using the data above, explain TWO reasons why teenagers and young people in Victoria face a higher risk of drowning.

1.

2.

QUESTION 1.2B — 2 MARKS

Victoria recorded *zero* drowning deaths in public swimming pools in 2024–25, but 25% of deaths were in home environments. What does this suggest about the importance of swimming at patrolled beaches and pools?

2 Beach Flags, Signals & Safe Swimming

KEY KNOWLEDGE — AUSTRALIAN BEACH FLAG SYSTEM

- **Red & Yellow flags** = patrolled swimming area — ALWAYS swim here
- **Black & white quartered** = surfers/watercraft zone — not for swimmers
- **Orange windsock** = offshore winds — no inflatables
- Lifeguards are trained professionals — always follow their instructions
- **Single red flag** = dangerous conditions, extreme caution or no entry
- **Yellow + black ball** = swimming only — no surfboards allowed
- **Purple flag** = dangerous marine life present
- BeachSafe app shows patrolled beaches near you: beachsafe.org.au

Source: Surf Life Saving Australia — https://sls.com.au | Life Saving Victoria — https://lsv.com.au

Activity 2.1 — Flag Identification ★ COLOUR REQUIRED — Individual · ~8 min

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Below are six beach flag diagrams. Write the correct name and meaning of each flag in the boxes provided.



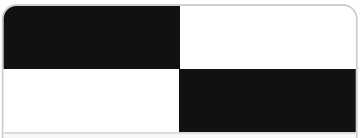
Flag 1: _____

Meaning: _____



Flag 2: _____

Meaning: _____



Flag 3: _____

Meaning: _____



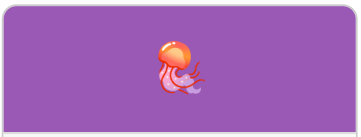
Flag 4: _____

Meaning: _____



Flag 5: _____

Meaning: _____



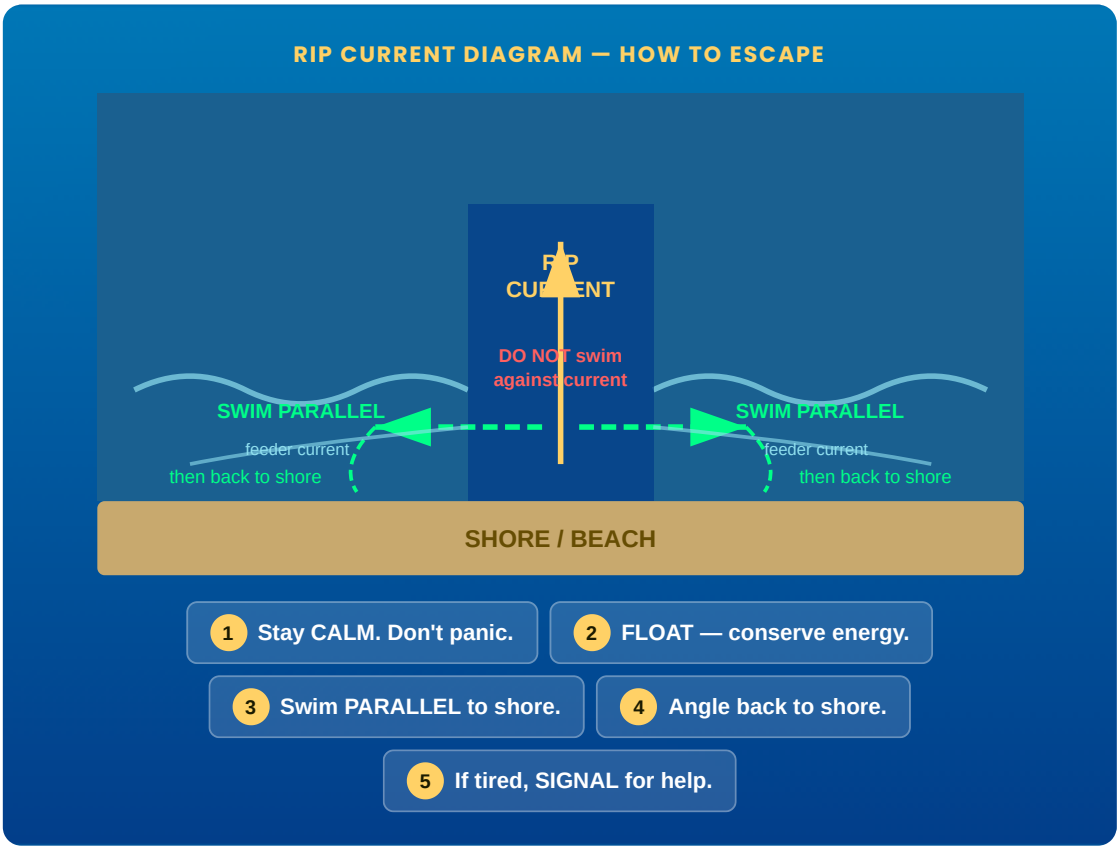
Flag 6: _____

Meaning: _____

Activity 2.2 — Rip Currents: How to Escape ★ COLOUR REQUIRED

Individual · ~10 min

Rip currents are one of the leading causes of drowning at Australian beaches. They are fast-moving channels of water that flow from the shore out to sea. Study the diagram carefully, then answer the questions below.



QUESTION 2.2A 3 MARKS

Using the diagram above, describe in your own words the THREE steps you would take if caught in a rip current.

Step 1:

Step 2:

Step 3:

QUESTION 2.2B 2 MARKS

Why is it dangerous to try to swim directly against a rip current towards shore?

SCENARIO

Liam is a 14-year-old who went to the beach with friends on a hot summer day. They went to an unpatrolled beach. Liam swam out past where the others were standing and felt himself being pulled away from shore. He began panicking and tried to sprint-swim directly back to the beach, but was getting more tired. His friends noticed and didn't know what to do.

QUESTION 2.2C 4 MARKS

Identify TWO mistakes Liam and his friends made, and explain what they should have done differently.

Mistake 1:

They should have:

Mistake 2:

They should have:

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3 Emergency Response — DRS ABCD

KEY KNOWLEDGE — THE DRS ABCD ACTION PLAN

- **D**anger — check for hazards before approaching
- **S**end — call 000 (triple zero) for emergency services
- **B**reathing — look, listen, feel for up to 10 seconds
- **D**efibrillation — use AED if available; follow voice prompts
- **R**esponse — check if the person responds to you
- **A**irway — tilt head back, lift chin, check for obstruction
- **C**PR — 30 compressions, 2 breaths; repeat until help arrives
- THROW, DON'T GO — use reach or throw rescue to avoid becoming a victim

Source: St John Ambulance Victoria — https://www.stjohnvic.com.au/first-aid-resources/

⚠️ **Critical Safety Rule — THROW, DON'T GO:** Most bystanders who enter dangerous water to help end up drowning themselves. Always attempt a reach or throw rescue first. Throw a rope, towel, kickboard, esky lid, or any floating object. Only enter water to rescue if you are trained to do so.

Activity 3.1 — DRS ABCD Memory Activity

Individual · ~5 min

Complete the DRS ABCD blocks below. Fill in the word that each letter stands for.

D	R	S	A	B	C	D
DANGER	_____	_____	_____	_____	_____	_____

In the table below, describe what you would DO at each step if you found someone unconscious face-down at the edge of a swimming pool.

Step	What I would do:
D	*e.g. Look around for any electricity, chemicals, or pool hazards before approaching...*
R	
S	
A	
B	
C	
D	

Activity 3.2 — Rescue Scenario Analysis

Pairs · ~12 min

SCENARIO — THE RIVER ROPE SWING

Scene: It is a hot February day. You and your friends are at a popular (but unpatrolled) rope swing over a river. A 16-year-old you don't know swings out, lets go, and hits the water awkwardly. He sinks and doesn't come back up. His friends are watching from the bank. One of them jumps in to help and also starts struggling. You are standing on the bank. You have a towel, a rope attached to the swing, and your phone.

QUESTION 3.2A — 2 MARKS

What is your FIRST action and why? (Consider the 'throw, don't go' principle)

QUESTION 3.2B — 2 MARKS

Why is it dangerous that the friend jumped in? What risk does this create?

QUESTION 3.2C — 3 MARKS

If you successfully pull the unconscious teenager to the bank and he is not breathing, list the DRS ABCD steps you would take in order.

1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____

4. _____ 5. _____ 6. _____

4 Making Safe Decisions Near Water

KEY KNOWLEDGE — FACTORS THAT INCREASE RISK

- Peer pressure to swim in dangerous locations
- Cold water shock (involuntary gasp reflex)
- Swimming alone with no-one watching
- Ignoring warning signs and flags
- Overestimating your swimming ability
- Alcohol and drug use impairs judgment
- Jumping or diving without checking depth
- Inflatable toys in open water with offshore winds

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LSV SWIMSAFE RULES — YOUR 5 RULES BEFORE YOU ENTER WATER

- **Read Signs** — Always check warning signs, beach flags, and notices before entering any waterway
- **Enter Feet First** — Never dive or jump into water you don't know — hidden rocks and shallow edges cause spinal injuries
- **Stay In Depth** — Only swim where you can comfortably stand, unless you are a confident, experienced swimmer
- **Swim With a Friend** — Never swim alone — drowning is silent, so having someone watch means someone can call for help
- **Signal For Help** — Raise ONE arm if you're in trouble. Float, conserve energy, and keep signalling until help arrives

Source: Life Saving Victoria SwimSafe Program — https://lsv.com.au

Activity 4.0 — Hazard Mapping

Pairs · ~10 min

For each Victorian water environment below, list at least THREE specific hazards. Rank each hazard H (High), M (Medium) or L (Low) risk.

Environment	Hazards (list at least 3)	Risk Level (H/M/L)	How to stay safe
Patrolled Beach (e.g. Torquay, Mornington)	*1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____*		
River / Dam (e.g. Yarra River, Lake Eildon)	*1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____*		
Pool (public, school, or backyard)	*1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____*		

QUESTION 4.0A — 2 MARKS

Which environment is MOST dangerous overall, and why? Use Victorian drowning statistics to support your answer.

Activity 4.1 — Risk vs. Benefit Analysis

Individual · ~10 min

For each situation, identify the RISK(S) and a SAFER ALTERNATIVE.

Situation	Risk(s)	Safer Alternative
Swimming at an unpatrolled beach at night on a dare from friends		
Using an inflatable lilo in the ocean on a windy day		
Jumping into a river from rocks without knowing the depth		
Going for a swim alone in a dam on a hot day		

QUESTION 4.1A 3 MARKS

Peer pressure is one of the key reasons young people take risks near water. Describe a strategy you could use to resist peer pressure to swim somewhere unsafe. Give a specific example of what you might say to your friends.

Strategy:

What I could say:

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5 Victorian Inland Waterways, Cold Water & Rescue

Activity 5.1 — Cold Water Shock Research Task

Individual / pair · ~15 min

Victorian rivers, dams and lakes can be dangerously cold even on a hot summer day. Cold water shock is a physiological response that can incapacitate even strong swimmers.

> **Cold Water Shock Facts:** When you suddenly enter cold water (below about 15°C), your body triggers an involuntary gasp reflex, rapid breathing, increased heart rate and blood pressure, and muscle weakness. These responses can cause you to inhale water and drown within minutes, even in shallow water. Alpine lakes such as Lake Eildon are fed by snowmelt and can remain below 15°C even in December and January.

QUESTION 5.1A — 2 MARKS

Describe TWO physical effects cold water has on the body that can increase the risk of drowning.

1.

2.

QUESTION 5.1B — 2 MARKS

What are TWO precautions you should take if you plan to swim or fish at an inland waterway in Victoria?

1.

2.

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RESEARCH QUESTION 5.1C 2 MARKS

Visit one of the sites below and find ONE fact about Victorian inland waterway safety you didn't know before. Write the exact URL of the page you found it on.

`https://www.vic.gov.au/water-safety · https://lsv.com.au · https://paddle.org.au · https://www.parks.vic.gov.au`

Fact:

Source URL:

Activity 5.2 — Throw Rescue: Rank Your Equipment

Groups of 3–4 · ~8 min

Based on guidelines from the **Royal Life Saving Society Australia (RLSSA)**, the safest rescues keep YOU out of the water. Rank the items below from BEST (1) to WORST (5) — and explain WHY in the third column.

Item	Rank (1–5)	Why? (explain advantage or limitation)
Coiled rope / throw bag		
Life ring attached to the jetty		
Jumping in and swimming to them		
Throwing a pool noodle or esky lid		
Holding out a towel or clothing from the bank		

Source: RLSSA rescue guidelines — https://www.royallifesaving.com.au

Activity 5.3 — Alcohol, Risk & Water

Individual · ~8 min

Alcohol is a significant factor in Victorian drowning deaths. Use what you know to answer the questions below.

QUESTION 5.3A 3 MARKS

List THREE specific ways that alcohol affects the body that increase the risk of drowning.

1.

2.

3.

QUESTION 5.3B 2 MARKS

A group of older teenagers are at a pool party. Some have been drinking. One decides to swim "to cool off." What are TWO specific risk factors that make this more dangerous than swimming sober?

1.

2.

🦴 Activity 5.4 — Diving, Shallow Water & Spinal Injury

Individual · ~12 min

⚠ KEY DATA — AUSTRALIAN DIVING & SPINAL INJURY STATISTICS

- Unsafe diving accounts for approximately **10%** of all spinal cord injuries and **20%** of quadriplegia cases in Australia *(AIHW Diving Injury Report)*
- **Two-thirds** of patients suffer permanent disability — the cervical spine (neck vertebrae) fractures on impact and the spinal cord cannot regenerate
- **Core prevention message: "Feet First, First Time, Every Time"** — always enter unknown water feet-first, and check depth on every visit regardless of prior experience
- **95%** of aquatic spinal injury patients are male — the highest-risk age group is children aged **10–14**
- A sandbank can form or shift between visits — tidal variation, drought, flooding, and sediment all change depth without warning

Sources: AIHW — aihw.gov.au · Royal Perth Hospital spinal injury review · RLSSA — royallifesaving.com.au

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Case study	What happened	Key lesson
Terrigal Wharf NSW, 2025	A teenage boy dived from a wharf into water he believed was deep. Serious spinal injuries. Helicopter evacuation to hospital.	Wharves and jetties can sit over surprisingly shallow or tidal water. Height above does not indicate depth below.
Torquay Front Beach Victoria, 2025	A teenage boy suffered a serious suspected spinal injury diving at a surf beach and was airlifted to hospital.	Surf beach sandbanks shift with every tide. Depth at any point is constantly and unpredictably changing.
Bawley Beach Jetty NSW, 2024	A young man dived from a jetty he had used safely before. A sandbank had recently formed beneath the jumping spot between his visits.	False confidence from prior experience. Always check depth on every single visit, regardless of prior experience.

QUESTION 5.4A 2 MARKS

The data shows 95% of aquatic spinal injury patients are male and the highest-risk age group is 10–14 years. Explain why *you* might be in a higher-risk group for this type of injury, and what specific behaviour creates that risk.

QUESTION 5.4B 2 MARKS

The Bawley Beach case (NSW 2024) shows a young man was seriously injured at a jetty he had used safely before — a sandbank had formed since his last visit. Explain why *"I've done it here before"* is a dangerous substitute for checking water depth.

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QUESTION 5.4C 2 MARKS

Unsafe diving causes 10% of all spinal cord injuries in Australia. If you saw a friend about to dive into a river or dam at an unfamiliar location, design ONE specific, realistic action — what would you say or do, and why?

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6 Personal Action Plan & Communication Campaign

Activity 6.1 — Personal Water Safety Action Plan

Individual · ~12 min

6.1A — MY SWIMMING GOALS

What is one swimming or water safety skill you want to improve this year?

6.1B — MY SWIMSAFE COMMITMENT

Write down the FIVE LSV SwimSafe rules. Circle the one that is most important for you personally. Explain why below.

Rule 1:

Rule 2:

Rule 3:

Rule 4:

Rule 5:

Most important for me because:

6.1C — MY SAFETY ACTION PLAN

Choose the scenario most relevant to you (circle one):

Beach day at Torquay / Mornington Peninsula · River or lake trip (e.g. Yarra, Eildon) · Pool party at a friend's house · Kayaking / paddling trip

Plan Element	My Plan:
Hazards I might face	
Safety strategies I'll use	
Emergency plan (if something goes wrong)	
Equipment I'll bring	
Who I'll go with (buddy rule!)	

Activity 6.2 — Water Safety Communication Campaign (Assessment Task)

`Individual · ~25 min · Summative`

Water safety is a community responsibility. Create a short water safety communication product for a specific audience. Choose ONE option:

> **All options must include:** at least ONE accurate statistic with its source URL · a clear, specific safety message · a call to action (what you want the audience to DO)

OPTION A — SOCIAL MEDIA POST FOR TEENS: Design 1–2 Instagram/TikTok slides for 13–17 year olds. Include a statistic, a visual element (drawn or described), and a call to action.

OPTION B — LETTER TO A YEAR 5 STUDENT: Write a 200-word letter explaining three things they must know about water safety in Victoria before summer.

OPTION C (EXTENSION) — MULTILINGUAL COMMUNITY FACT SHEET: Design a simple fact sheet explaining beach flags and Victorian waterway dangers for someone new to Australia. Include at least 5 key points and 2 statistics.

Plan your campaign:

Option chosen: _____

Target audience: _____

Statistic I will use: _____

Source URL: _____

Key message: _____

Call to action: _____

Draft your campaign here (or attach a separate page / digital work):

Write or sketch your campaign content here...

Self-Assessment — Rate Your Confidence

Circle your confidence level for each area after completing this workbook.

Skill / Knowledge Area	Not yet confident	Getting there	Confident
Identifying beach flags and their meanings	○	○	○
Knowing what to do if caught in a rip current	○	○	○
Following DRS ABCD in an emergency	○	○	○
Recalling all 5 LSV SwimSafe rules	○	○	○
Making safe decisions near water	○	○	○
Understanding Victorian drowning statistics	○	○	○
Identifying hazards at different waterway types	○	○	○
Explaining the Throw, Don't Go rescue principle	○	○	○

One thing I want to learn more about:

Swim & Water Safety — Student Workbook (Print Version)
Victorian Curriculum F–10 Version 2.0 · HPE · Year 7–8 · VC2HP8P08 · VC2HP8P09 · VC2HP8P10 · VC2HP8M01

Life Saving Victoria: lsv.com.au · Drowning Reports: lsv.com.au/what-we-do/research-advocacy
RLSSA: royallifesaving.com.au · BeachSafe: beachsafe.org.au
Paddle Aus: paddle.org.au · Parks Vic: park.vic.gov.au
Victorian Curriculum: victoriancurriculum.vcaa.vic.edu.au

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